India, officially the Republic of India,[j][20] is a country in South Asia. It is the world's seventh-largest country by area and the largest by population.[21] Bounded by the Indian Ocean on the south, the Arabian Sea on the southwest, and the Bay of Bengal on the southeast, it shares land borders with Pakistan to the west;[k] China, Nepal, and Bhutan to the north; and Bangladesh and Myanmar to the east. In the Indian Ocean, India is near Sri Lanka and the Maldives.[l] Modern humans arrived on the Indian subcontinent from Africa by 55,000 years ago.[23] Settled life emerged in the western margins of the Indus river basin 9,000 years ago, evolving into the Indus Valley Civilisation of the third millennium BCE.[24] By 1200 BCE, an archaic form of Sanskrit, an Indo-European language, diffused into India from the northwest,[25] its earliest hymns containing elements of what would become Hinduism.[26] The pre-existing Dravidian and other languages were gradually superseded in India's northern plains.[27] Across the central stretch of these plains, rapid urbanisation took place, and after 500 BCE a caste-based, hereditary, form of social stratification began to solidify as Hinduism took fuller shape.[28] During this period, Buddhism and Jainism arose, proclaiming social orders unlinked to heredity.[29] The subsequent emergence of the loose-knit[30][31] Maurya and Gupta Empires gave rise to wide-ranging cultural and scientific creativity.[32] However, these eras saw a steady decline in women's status,[33] alongside the eventual institutionalisation of untouchability.[34] In South India, across the first millennium CE, the Middle kingdoms transmitted Dravidian language scripts and cultural traditions to Southeast Asia.[35] Well before the millennium's end, Judaism, Christianity, Islam and Zoroastrianism had become established on India's southern and western coasts.[36] Early in the 2nd millennium, Muslim armies from Central Asia intermittently overran India's northern plains,[37] eventually establishing the Delhi Sultanate, and drawing India into the cosmopolitan networks of medieval Islam.[38] In South India, the Vijayanagara Empire created a long-lasting composite culture.[39] During this era, Sikhism emerged in the Punjab, rejecting established religious institutions.[40][41] The Mughal Empire ushered in two centuries of economic expansion and relative peace,[42] leaving a rich architectural legacy.[43] Through its gradually expanding rule, the British East India Company consolidated territorial control over the subcontinent[44] while transforming India into a colonial economy.[45] British Crown rule began in 1858. Although equality before the law promised to Indians was slow to materialise,[46][47] technological changes were introduced[48] while modern education and the public life took root.[49][50] A nationalist movement emerged in India, the first in the non-European British Empire.[51][52] Noted for nonviolent resistance after 1920,[53] it was a major factor in ending British rule.[54] In 1947, the British Indian Empire was partitioned into the independent dominions of a Hindu-majority India and a Muslim-majority Pakistan. The partition brought large-scale loss of life and unprecedented migration.[55] The Constitution of India was adopted in 1950 and declared India to be a federal republic governed through a democratic parliamentary system; it guarantees freedom of speech, freedom of press,[56] and religious pluralism.[57] Amendments enacted from 1951 onwards strengthened affirmative action programmes to reduce caste inequality.[58] The reorganization of states in 1956 along linguistic lines, institutionalised regional language pride,[59] and led to the growth of regional literature and cinema.[60] During the 1970s, India reversed agricultural stagnation through the Green Revolution,[61] achieving national food security.[62] The country also altered the regional power balance through support for Bangladesh[63] and enacted constitutional reform to end princely privileges.[64] India's population grew from 361 million in 1951,[65] to approximately 1.464 billion in 2025.[66][m] Economic reforms of the 1990s integrated India's economy with the world's.[67] By the 2010s, the Indian economy had a stably high rate of growth.[68] A large middle class and a communications boom gained momentum.[69] However, challenges remain, including widening income gaps,[70] gender inequality[71] and environmental degradation.[72] In recent years India has seen a political shift toward majoritarianism.[73][74] A nuclear-weapon state with high military expenditure, India is among the world's largest economies

and a founding member of the United Nations,[75] while its cultural legacy encompasses 45 UNESCO World Heritage Sites.[76] India's megadiverse land features four biodiversity hotspots. Its wildlife is supported in protected habitats and traditionally viewed with cultural tolerance.[77] Etymology Main article: Names for India According to the Oxford English Dictionary, the English proper noun "India" derives most immediately from the Classical Latin India, a reference to a loosely-defined historical region of Asia stretching from South Asia to the borders of China. Further etymons are: Hellenistic Greek India (Ἰνδία); Ancient Greek Indos (Ἰνδός), or the River Indus; Achaemenian Old Persian Hinduš (an eastern province of the Achaemenid Empire); and Sanskrit Sindhu, or "river," but specifically the Indus river, and by extension its well-settled basin.[78] The Ancient Greeks referred to South Asians as Indoi, 'the people of the Indus'.[79] The term Bharat (Bhārat; pronounced [ˈbʱaːrət] ⓘ), mentioned in both Indian epic poetry and the Constitution of India,[80][81] is used in its variations by many Indian languages. A modern rendering of the historical name Bharatavarsha, which applied originally to North India,[82][83] Bharat gained increased currency from the mid-19th century as a native name for India.[80][84] Hindustan ([ɦɪndʊˈstaːn] ⓘ) is a Middle Persian name for India that became popular by the 13th century,[85] and was used widely since the era of the Mughal Empire. The meaning of Hindustan has varied, referring to a region encompassing the northern Indian subcontinent (present-day northern India and Pakistan) or to India in its near entirety.[80][84][86] History Main article: History of India Ancient India Manuscript illustration, c. 1650, of the Sanskrit epic Ramayana, composed in story-telling fashion c. 400 BCE – c. 300 CE[87] Cave 26, a Buddhist shrine, of the rock-cut Ajanta Caves Based on coalescence of Mitochondrial DNA and Y Chromosome data, the earliest extant lineages of modern humans on the Indian subcontinent had reached there from Africa between 80,000 and 50,000 years ago, and with high likelihood by 55,000 years ago.[23][n] Neolithic and chalcolithic cultures arose in the western margins of the Indus river basin around Mehrgarh in Balochistan, Pakistan after 7000 BCE.[o] These gradually evolved into the Indus Valley Civilisation, which flourished during 2500–1900 BCE in Pakistan and western India.[90][24] Centred around cities such as Mohenjo-daro, Harappa and Dholavira,[91] its characteristic features included steatite seals, a written script, urban planning, terracotta human figures and animal statuettes.[91][p] Between 1500 BCE and 1200 BCE, an archaic form of Sanskrit, an Indo-European language, diffused into India from the northwest. Its evidence today is found in the Rig Veda—the scripture associated with the historical Vedic religion, one of the progenitors of what later became Hinduism.[q][25][26] The settling of the Ganges river plain took place during the next millennium, when swathes of the river system's adjoining regions were deforested[r] and prepared for agriculture.[s][93] The Dravidian and other languages of India were supplanted in the north, creating a broad language family-divide, with the Indo-Aryan languages being spoken mainly in the north and west, and the Dravidian in some parts of east India and most of the south.[27][u] A second urbanisation took place in India by the middle-first-millennium BCE. In fortified cities in the central Ganges plain, social differentiation by caste, or varna, emerged.[28] Also, by the mid-millennium, two new religions arose: Jainism, based on the teachings of Mahavira, and Buddhism, based on those of the Buddha. Both stressed non-violence and abjured animal sacrifices conducted in Brahmanism[v] and birth into a fixed hereditary varna. By living ethically, lay people could rise socially and morally in these religions.[29][w] The rise of the two religions was a backdrop to the emergence of the first loose-knit, geographically extensive power in South Asia, the Maurya Empire.[30] During the rule of the founder's grandson, Ashoka (ca. 268–232 BCE), the empire briefly controlled the subcontinent's major urban hubs and arteries, except in the deep south.[97][x][y] The empire's period was notable for creativity in art, architecture, inscriptions, and produced texts.[32] Following his conquest of Kalinga, in which his forces caused immense loss of life, Ashoka adopted Buddhism, and subsequently commissioned numerous rock and pillar edicts throughout the Maurya